

The Veteran's Journey to a Degree: A Promise Derailed

America offers veterans a world-class education as a reward for their service. But for too many, the path from the military to a meaningful degree is broken.



The Journey Begins in a Land of Opportunity

1,076,358

Unique credentials available in the United States. From degrees and certificates to licenses and apprenticeships, the educational marketplace is vast and full of potential for transitioning service members.



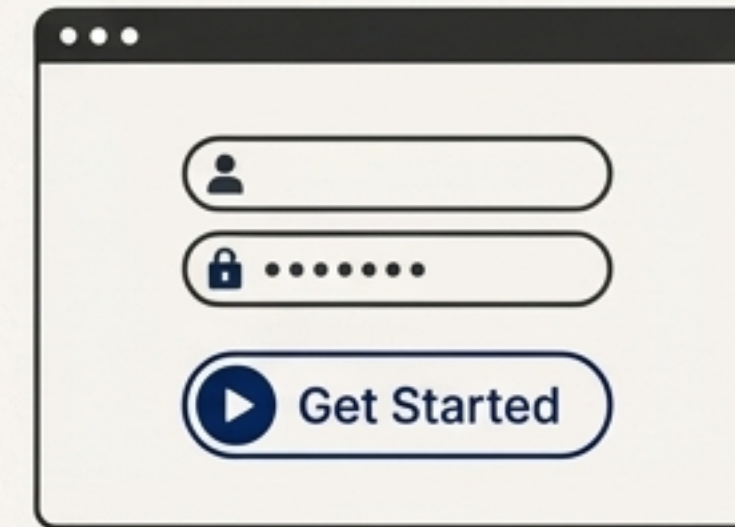
A Well-Equipped Journey: Tools and Funding for the Path Ahead

The Map & Compass Guidance Systems



Portals like Army COOL provide a “library” of authorized credentials, helping soldiers research options and align them with their military experience.

The Fuel for the Trip The Funding Engine



The Post-9/11 GI Bill and Credentialing Assistance (CA) provide generous funding—up to a combined \$4,500 per fiscal year—to cover tuition, training, exams, and materials. Requests are submitted through the streamlined ArmyIgnitED platform.

Veterans Embark with a Clear Expectation: Their Experience Should Count

Nearly half of all student veterans report that opportunities for military credit recognition are an important factor in their decision about which institution to attend.

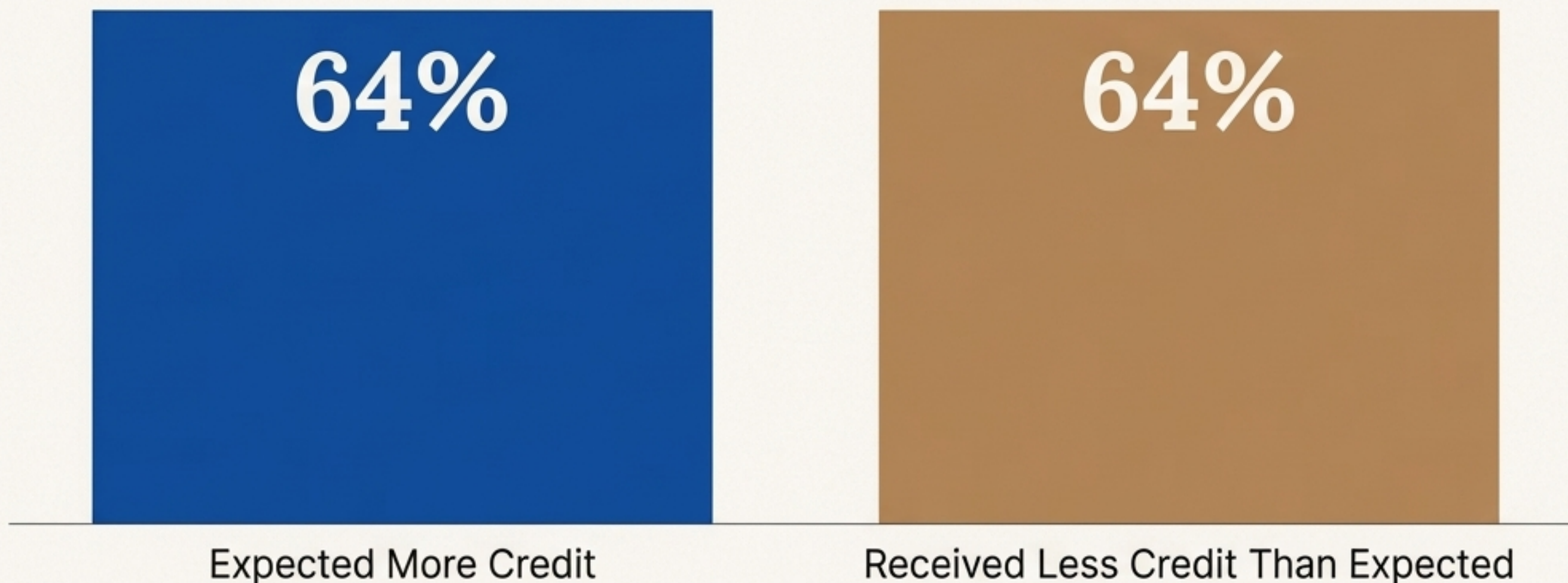
48% of all student veterans
57% of student veterans of color

“Many recommended that veterans consider opportunities for credit recognition in their decision about which institution to attend.”

Source: AIR, “Informing Improved Recognition of Military Learning,” July 2021.



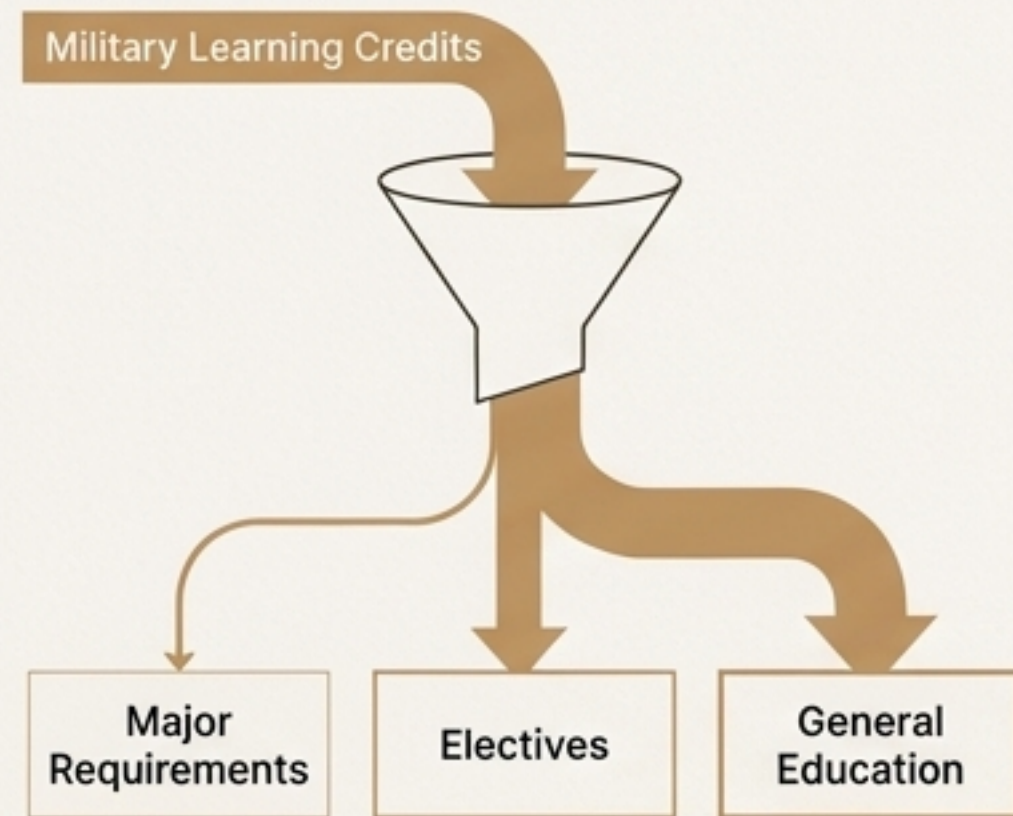
The First Detour: A Chasm Between Expectation and Reality



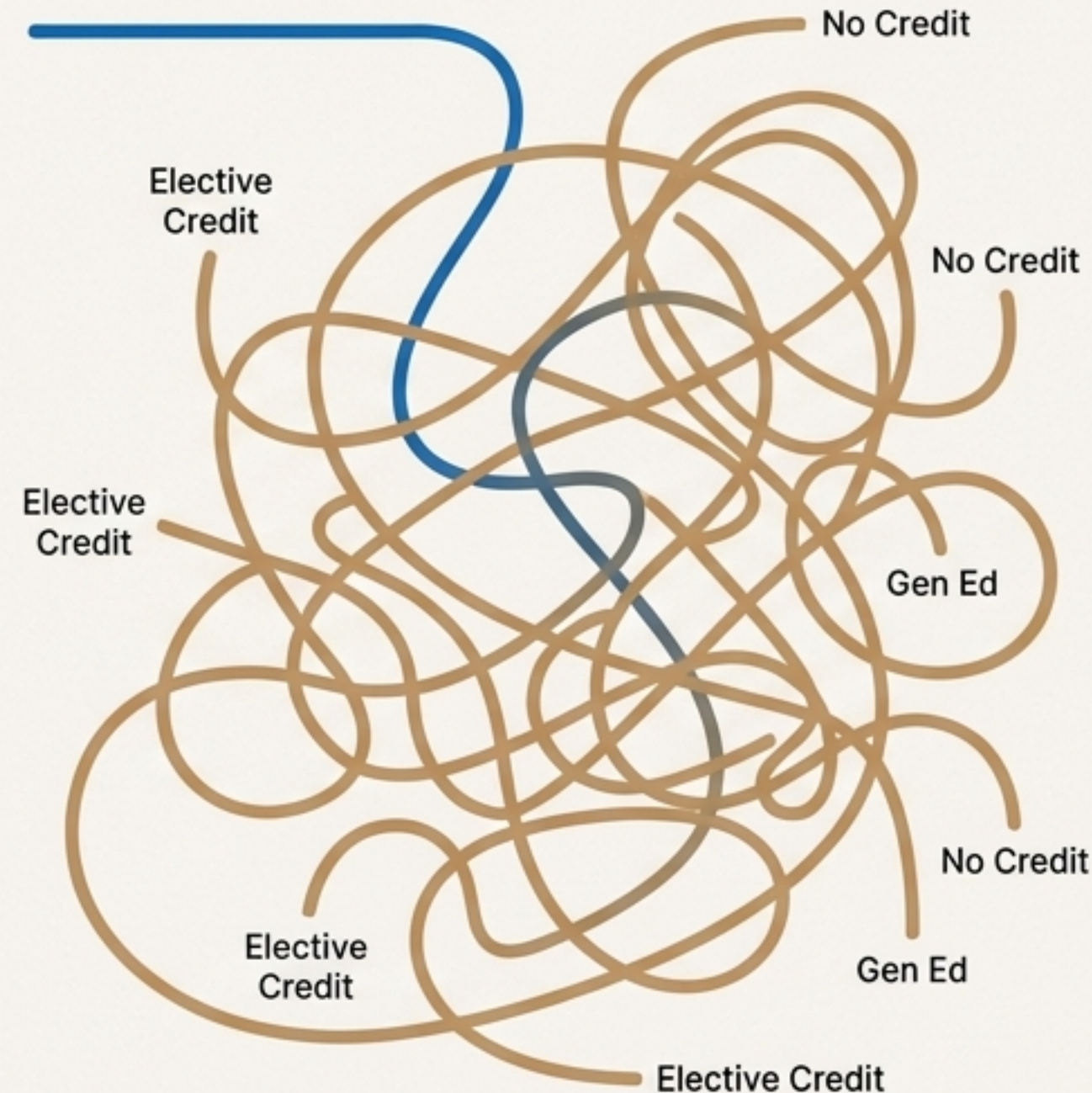
A staggering **64% of student veterans** who expected to receive credit reported getting less than they anticipated. The system meant to accelerate their journey is forcing them to retake ground they've already covered.

Lost in Translation: A Labyrinth of Inconsistent and Irrelevant Credit

Credit Given, But Not Where It Counts



- **79%** of credit received was for Electives.
- **55%** for General Education.
- Only **18%** of credit for military training was applied to a student's major.



A System of Contradictions

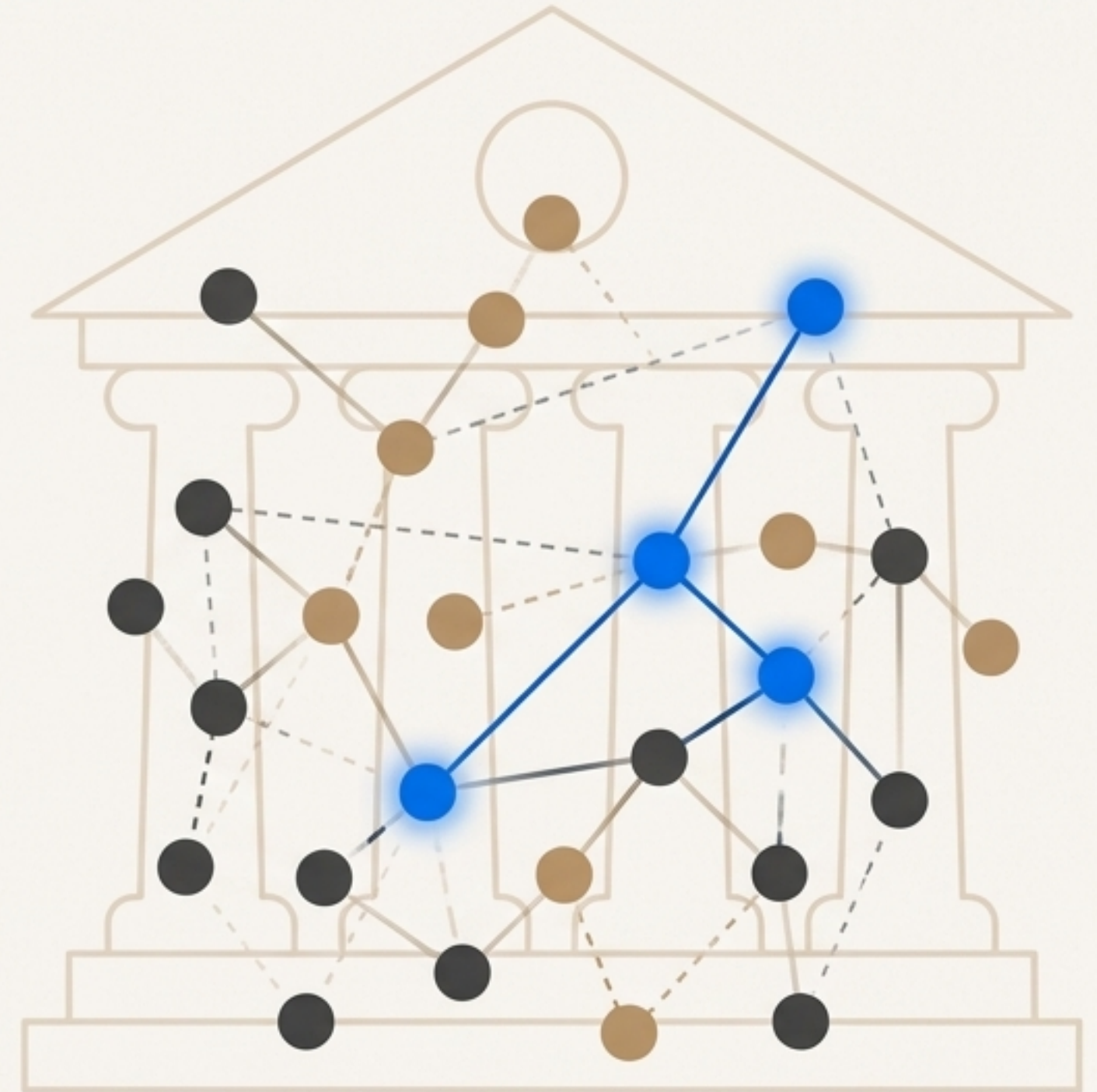
“ I have friends who went to a different university, and they are in the exact same point in their career as me. Exact same training, exact same time in, exact same experience, and they'd get, like, 19 credits. **It's very inconsistent.** ”

Inside the Institution: A System Unprepared for the Veteran Journey

Key Findings from a survey of university administrators and faculty:

- **Lack of Awareness:** A widespread lack of familiarity with Credit for Prior Learning (CPL) policies was a dominant theme. “I don’t know/unsure” was a common response across multiple questions.
- **Inconsistent Authority:** Most institutions (62%) do not apply ACE credit recommendations as written, delegating final decisions to individual academic departments, leading to inconsistency.
- **Siloed Knowledge:** The process often relies on individual “champions” rather than institutionalized systems.

“Champions keep it alive, but when they leave, it stops.” – Georgia Administrator Focus Group Participant



The Human Cost: Wasted Time, Redundant Work, and a Sense of Disrespect

“I had to reorder transcripts several times and after almost 2 months, a copy was finally processed... after speaking with admissions... none were accepted for my chosen degree anyways.”

– Student Veteran Focus Group Participant

“I probably wouldn’t have had to take at least half of those [general education classes] if I had gotten my credits applied.”

– Student Veteran Focus Group Participant

“Psychologically, I was at one point ready to throw in the towel because I do feel like there was a lot of things that could have been recognized, and so I didn’t have to do redundant things with 18-year-olds that were going through it for the first time.”

– Student Veteran Focus Group Participant

The Shocking Destination: A Negative Return on Investment



-\$9000

A **massive** expansion of college subsidies under the Post-9/11 GI Bill led to a modest 1.2 percentage point increase in B.A. completion. But the unintended consequence for veterans was a \$900 reduction in average annual earnings nine years after leaving the Army.

Source: NBER Working Paper 29024, "You Can't Handle The Truth: The Effects Of The Post-9/11 GI Bill On Higher Education And Earnings," July 2021.

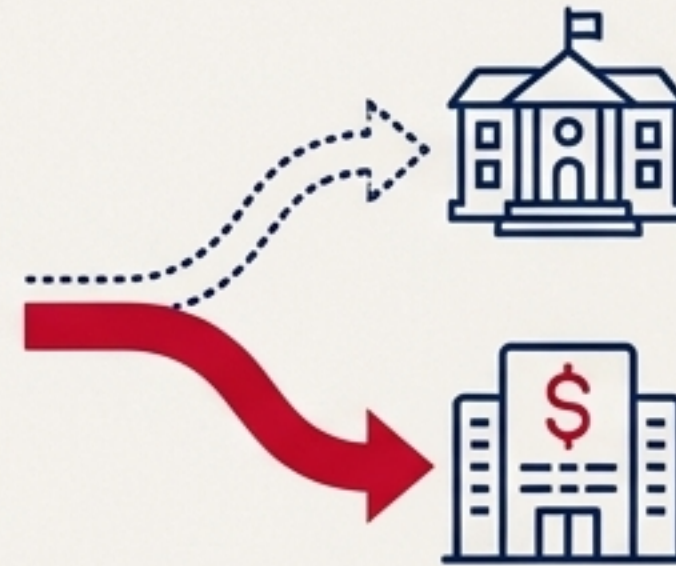
Deconstructing the Negative Return: Two Critical Factors

Lost Labor Market Experience



Increased time in college, especially for redundant or low-value courses, meant less time in the workforce gaining valuable experience and seniority. The educational investment did not outweigh the cost of lost time on the job.

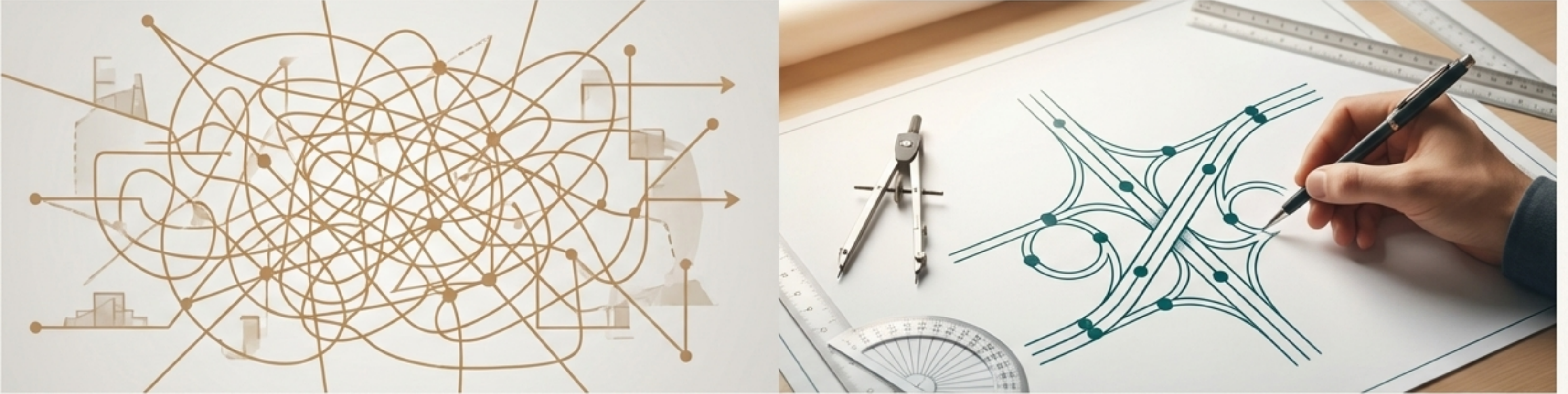
Low-Return Educational Investments



The subsidies induced enrollment, but often into lower-quality investments. Less advantaged veterans, in particular, saw increased enrollment in for-profit institutions, which correlated with larger negative earnings effects.

The PGIB successfully encouraged more veterans to enroll in college, but **without guidance, many were drawn out** of the labor market and into **programs that failed to deliver a positive financial return.**

It's Time to Redraw the Map for Success



The problem is not the veteran's ambition or the promise of the GI Bill. The problem is a system that offers a world of opportunity without a reliable map or a trustworthy guide. A successful journey requires three things:



A Clear, Consistent
Policy Framework



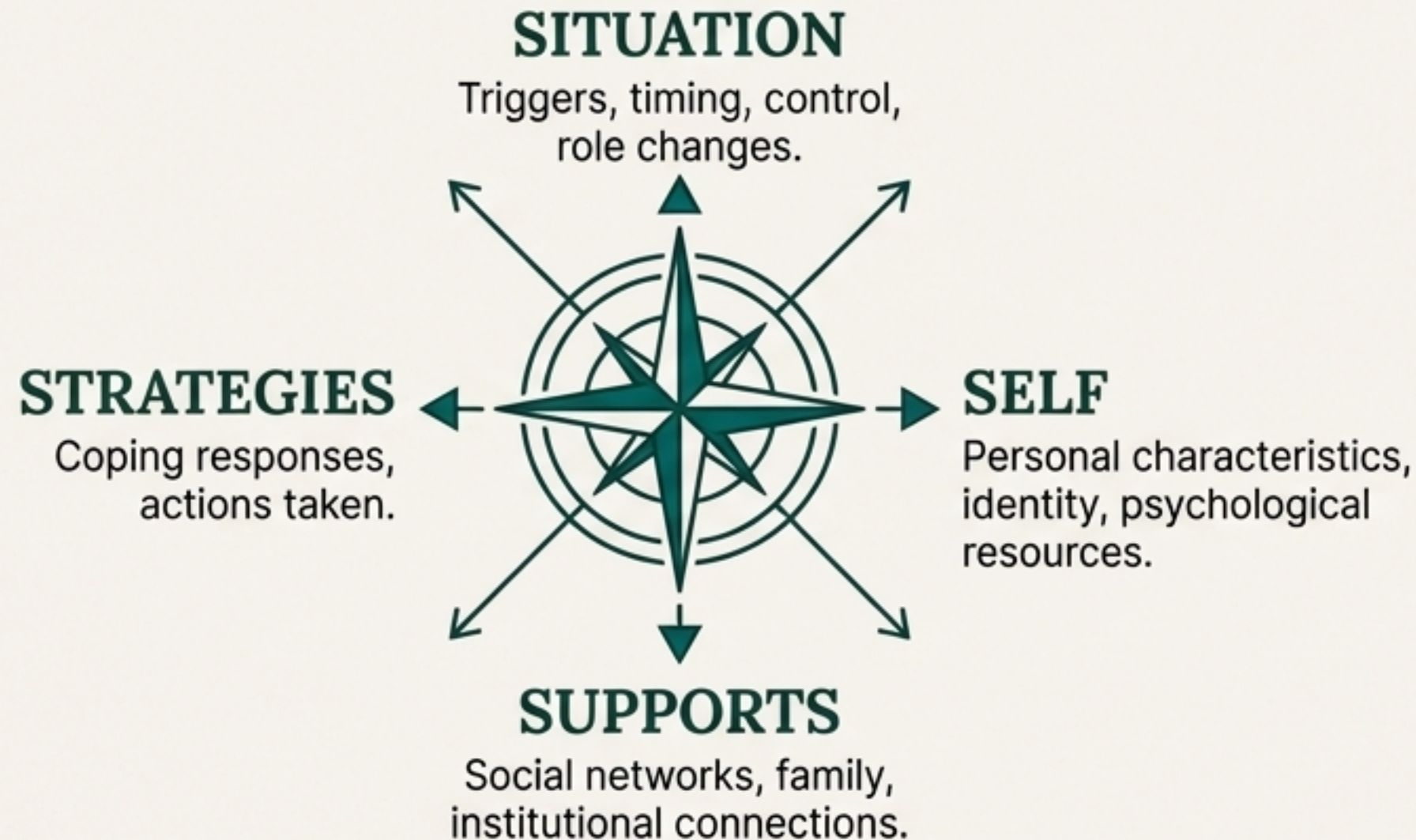
A Human-Centered
Guidance System



A Modern
Assessment Toolkit

Navigation Tool 1: | 1: A Holistic Advising Model

Effective guidance goes beyond just processing paperwork. It requires understanding the veteran's entire transition experience. Schlossberg's "Four S's" model provides a framework for this holistic approach.



Advisors equipped with this model can co-create individualized transition plans that account for a veteran's unique identity, challenges, and goals, guiding them toward high-return educational investments, not just the path of least resistance.

Navigation Tool 2: The Next Era of Assessment

The challenge isn't just about translating past training; it's about **not** recognizing present competency. The next era of assessment offers new ways to measure skills authentically, moving beyond traditional transcripts.

Introducing AI-Integrated Assessment

"Purposefully embedding AI tools as part of the learning and assessment experience to mirror real-world scenarios where humans and AI collaborate."

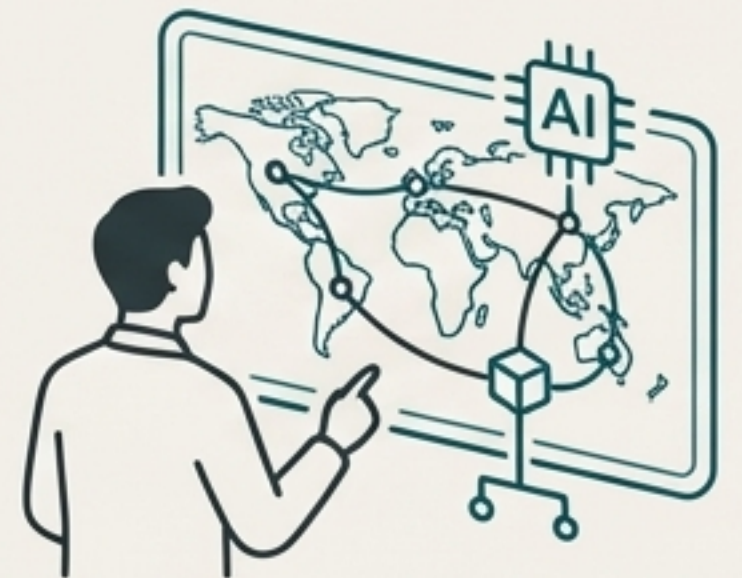


AI as a Simulated Collaborator

A veteran demonstrates leadership skills by interacting with an AI simulating a complex team dynamic.

AI for Immersive Learning

A veteran uses AI to create a simulation of a logistical challenge, applying their military expertise to solve it.



This approach doesn't just give "**credit for prior learning**"; it **demonstrates current mastery** in a way that is relevant to both the classroom and the future workplace.

A Blueprint for a Redesigned Journey



Consistent Policy & Transparent Pathways

Action

"Mandate consistent application of ACE recommendations. Create shared, statewide databases of military credit equivalencies."

Result

Predictability. Veterans know what to expect before they enroll.



Proactive, Holistic Advising

Action

"Train advisors in veteran-specific transition frameworks. Embed veteran support specialists in the admissions and advising process from day one."

Result

Guidance. Veterans are steered toward programs that align with their skills and career goals.



Modern, Competency-Based Assessment

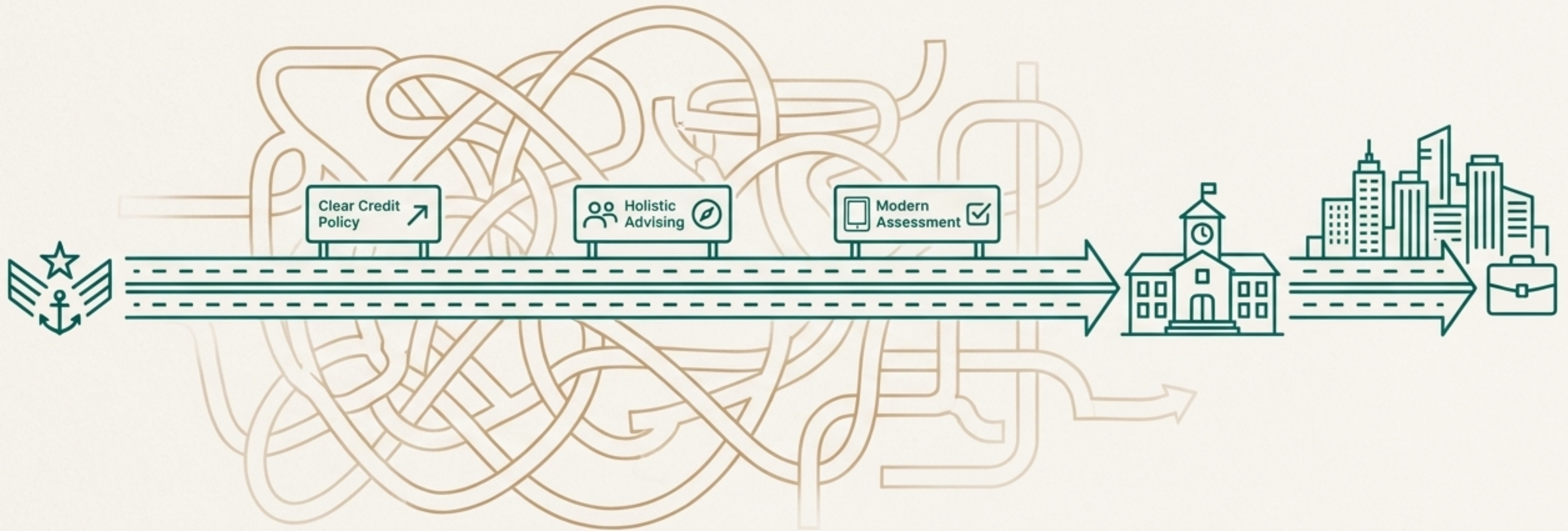
Action

"Pilot AI-Integrated and portfolio-based assessments to allow veterans to demonstrate mastery, not just document past training."

Result

Value. Military experience is recognized as a tangible asset that accelerates degree completion.

From a Path of Frustration to a Highway for Success



It is time to honor their service with a system that works. By redrawing the map, we can turn a promise derailed into a promise fulfilled.